

# What is sociocracy ?

Sociocracy is a form of governance that offers effective ways to share power. Using sociocracy, decisions can be more inclusive, egalitarian, and harmonious, therefore better meeting everyone's needs. (Wilder, 2020: 4).

The goal of sociocracy is to provide a framework for including all voices in an organization in order to "respect the equal value of people," (Buck & Villines, 2007 p. 29) and to ensure that "no one is ignored" (Rau & Gonzales, 2018, p. 3).

When we speak of sociocracy we mean the specific form of SCM (Sociocratic Circle-organization Method), which was invented by Gerard Endenburg in the 1970s for his own company Endenburg Electronics. Since then, it spread out from the Netherlands world-wide.

**SCM is based on following four basic principles:**

## **1. The Consent-principle rules the decision making process.**

A decision is made when the present circle members have given their consent to this decision following a process where everyone speaks in rounds. Consent means: there are no paramount and argued objections to this proposal.

## **2. An organization is made up of circles**

A circle is a semi-autonomous entity that makes its decisions independently, within limits that have been given by a higher circle with consent.

Within these limits, a circle can define its own aim and domain in alignment with the higher circle, create and lead the process to achieve that aim, and it may delegate the execution of tasks to the circle members or to further sub-circles.

The circle organizes the three elements of (1) leading (planning / deciding), (2) doing (executing, running) and (3) measuring (evaluating / learning). Together, they constitute the "circle-process".

## **3. Two circles are linked together by a double link**

At least two people from a circle take part in the decision-making process of the next higher circle: the person in the leadership role and the elected delegate, who possess separated roles. This brings a four eyes control to the higher levels, while distributing responsibility. The delegate has the role of making sure the circle is functioning, whereas the leader has the role of fulfilling requirements from a higher circle. The linkage between the two allows information as well as power to flow from bottom to top and vice-versa.

## **4. The distribution of tasks and functions is done through sociocratic "open" elections**

The circle elects people in accordance with the consent-principle, and following an open argumentation process. This guarantees that the roles are fulfilled with full support of the circle and in accordance with what has been consented in the circle.